increase the problem exponentially. Each bit of compromised information must be assessed not only on its own, but in relation to every other piece of data. As the numbers mount, the maths becomes formidable. Four bits of information have 24 possible combinations. Seven have 5,040. Ten have more than three million. If Snowden has taken a million documents, the permutations that—in theory—need to be examined exceed the number of atoms in the universe.

Snowdenistas dispute claims of colossal damage. Foreign intelligence services in Russia or elsewhere do not and will not have access to the stolen material, they maintain. But dealing with secrets is a highly technical and complicated business. People build their careers on it. It requires elaborate procedures to store the information, to set and administer levels of access, to monitor who sees it, when, why and how, and particularly to authorise, log and track any copies made. It requires specially built premises, and staff who must be carefully recruited and trained and subjected to regular screening. The whole setup—with its physical, bureaucratic and human elements—involves regular checks, and possibly professional penetration tests, in which expert outsiders are tasked with trying to break the security systems. It is also designed to minimise the effects of any breach—for example by seeding the data with tell-tales (to highlight if it is being misused) or booby-traps (to act as a deterrent to malefactors). All of this takes place in the knowledge that the world's most sophisticated intelligence agencies regard other countries' secret data as a top priority.

Snowden's allies may be admirable journalists. But they do not have the experience or resources to protect the information he has stolen. Their offices cannot be made safe against electronic eavesdropping. They do not know how to make their computers truly secure. The idea that the material is safe because it is encrypted is shockingly naïve: it is child's play for a sophisticated